



Wearable cooler jacket

The 686 x Pabst Blue Ribbon Sixer, an insulated jacket also doubles as a wearable cooler for your drinks <http://digit.in/WearACooler>



Anti-drone laser cannon

Lockheed Martin has developed a giant laser blaster and is demonstrating it by blowing autonomous drones out of the sky <http://digit.in/KillADrone>

Gateways to Hell

A look at the biggest man-made and natural holes in the earth, and what we learnt from them

Robert Sovereign-Smith | robert@digit.in

F

or a lot of us, when we were kids, digging holes was a wonderful experience. What was not to like as a child? You dig into the ground, you extract mud, you build mounds and various shapes, you get dirty, the lower you go in the ground the more the mud changes (wet, cool, warm, etc)... it was just a wonderful experience. Our parents might or might not have agreed, depending on who had to wash our clothes, and of course sometimes you would dig up a creepy crawly that would freak them out. Holes are just as fascinating to us as adults as well (get your mind out of the gutter), and the bigger they are the more fascinated we are with them. Hopefully this article will prove us right, because you will be fascinated by all the big holes that follow.

When it comes to holes, there are those that nature made and mankind discovered, and then those that mankind created itself. Both are equally fascinating, but in order to better categorise this article, we're going to divvy them up in that way:

NATURAL HOLES



Not all natural holes are on land. The **Great Blue Hole** is a giant, circular, submarine sinkhole off the coast of the country of Belize. It's 318 m (1,043 feet) across and 124 m (407 feet) deep. It's considered to be one of the best places on earth to go diving, and is a world heritage site as per UNESCO.



Xiaozhai Tiankeng: Located in China, this is the world's deepest sinkhole. It's about 626 metres (2,050 feet) long, 537 m (1,760 feet) wide and 662 m (2,170 feet) deep. To fill it, you'd need about 119 million cubic meters of stuff!



Credit: Texas Parks and Wildlife

While all the other pictures on this list are of the holes, this one is of bats emerging from the **Devil's Sinkhole** in Texas. The sinkhole itself is small – 18 m (60 feet) across and 122 m (400 feet) deep. However, we're showing you bats, because the hole is home to several million Mexican free-tailed bats. Between April to October, at sunset, millions of bats come flying out of the Devil's sinkhole in search of food. Not a place to be if you're scared of bats!



Qattara Depression: Sometimes a hole is so big that you cannot even see it! The Qattara Depression is in the north west of Egypt, and the lowest point is 133 m (436 feet) below sea level. However, this "hole" is about 300 km long and 135 km wide (maximum length and width), and has a surface area of about 19,605 square km!



Darvaza Gas Crater: Popularly named the Door to Hell, this gas crater in Turkmenistan is a mix of being man-made and natural. While exploring for oil, a dig came across a gas pocket, which then collapsed, swallowing up the excavation camp. It's thought that geologists set it on fire thinking that the gas would burn out in a week. It's now been burning continuously for over 40 years! It's not the biggest hole here at 69 m (226 feet) across and 30 m (98 feet) deep, but it's one of the most fascinating.